Good Job, Buddy

By Kathi Appelt

INTRODUCTION

Most people have crushes at some point in their lives. You know you have a crush on someone when you experience a powerful rush of feeling for the person, who you may not even know. You admire them, dream about them, feel happy when you see them or spend all your time counting the minutes until you will see them again. These powerful, and let's face it, irrational, emotions usually go away after a time, but it is hard to handle this overwhelming attraction when you are in the midst of it. Especially when you're in the midst of it at work. God job, Buddy by Kathi Appelt.

Food City, 2 A.M., he tucks in his

Red and black uniform shirt as

He passes the paperback books

Where he knows she'll arrive soon.

All the masters of mystery are there:

Mary Higgins Clark,

Clive Cussler,

Richard North Patterson,

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Dean Koontz most of all.

He hurries by, tonight's the night, he knows it . . .

He loves to work this shift,

The fluorescent lights humming,

A steady thrum just behind his ears.

He and the other boys load cases of Ragu and

Hamburger Helper onto carts,

Roll them down the aisles,

There they slice the cardboard,

A jagged swish of utility knives.

He loves the danger of it, the pull of the blade toward

His thigh, knowing a slip could sever

His thumb or his first finger, could slice

Through his black denim pants, the

Ones he wears every night, required.

It's a dance he does with the razor blade and boxes

a-one, a-two, a-three . . .

would Lacey dance if he asked?

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He glances at paperbacks –
Too early, Dean Koontz, he thinks.

He places the jars and bottles in quick
Rows on the shelves, labels facing out like flags –
The Republic of Kraft, the United Emirates
Of Nabisco, the Duchy of Birds Eye,
The kingdom of discounts and coupons and
A greeting card for every occasion.
Oh, would she dance if he asked?
The young night manager, Roy, turns
Off the subliminal music – Neil Sedaka,
Marvin Gaye, Barry Manilow – Mandy or Mandy –
And pipes in the local rock station, KRUD<
Heavy metal washes down the aisles in waves of
Drums and electricity, it races up his feet, through the
Bones in his legs, pumps the blood right through his
chest.
"Yeehaw," he wants to scream. "Yeehaw!" he screams.
He loves heavy metal, its driving pulse.

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Soon he finds his own subliminal rhythm,
He's got the beat . . . canned tomatoes fly
Onto the metal shelves, Campbell's Cream of Mushroom
Settles neatly next to Split Pea, boxes of Jell-O –
Raspberry, cranberry, lemon – line up like soldiers
Waiting for inspection. He stands back and salutes.
Who could have dreamed he'd get such satisfaction out
of
Rows of instant gelatin? Who could have dreamed
He'd dream so much about her . . . Lacey.

Roy pats him on the shoulder. "Good job, buddy,"
He shouts over the grinding music. Good job, he thinks
As he glances at his watch – 3:30. She should be here
soon.
His steps are full of little hops he can't stop himself
from taking.
Good job, he thinks as he sings along
With Jack from produce up to his knees
In cantaloupes fresh from the Valley,
Sweet and round and juicy.

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Ahh . . . cantaloups . . . ahh . . .
Lacey!

Good job, he thinks, as he walks to cereal, Aisle 14,
His favorite – and no wonder – all his childhood friends
Are there
Tony,
Snap, Crackle, and Pop,
Count Chocula,
Fred and Barney . . .
But she, she should be here soon,
He looks at Cap'n Crunch - - why didn't you
Warn me, he asks? Then lines up the Trix and Kix
And Cocoa Puffs, Froot Loops, Cheerios, and Total . . .
He's almost to the end of the aisle, somewhere
Between Post and General Mills, near the
Check-out counter, he turns the corner,

Smack! She's there! Lacey,
Parked in the paperback books
Just like he knew she would be

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4 A.M., like clockwork, like an alarm
His heart skips at least three beats,
He finishes with the Raisin Bran.

Almost every night, after her shift at the Pancake House,
Still wearing her blue apron and plastic Lacey name tag,
She floats into Food City, blond hair
Tied back, back, back Lacey.
He holds a box of Grape-Nuts against his chest and watches . . .
Each night she reaches behind the stack of mysteries, and pulls out the newest Dean Koontz
. . . no one asks her to pay for it. What is it about Dean Koontz?
Once after she left, he hurried to paperbacks and
Pulled out the copy she had so recently held.
He brought it to his face and breathed
In the scent of her – pancakes, strawberries,
And something else . . . a mystery.
The music bounced along the linoleum

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Filled the bags of miniature marshmallows
And frozen shrimp, filled his nostrils,
His eardrums, his fingers with resonance
So deep he couldn't name it.
Would she dance with Dean Koontz?
He knew she would.
But what did Dean Koontz know about her
Quiet manner, her punctuality, her small frame,
The smell of syrup?
He sighed. Metallica rolled toward
Him from the loudspeaker. All at once he
Hated Metallica, its ear-splitting wall of noise.
There she was with her mysteries
All alone, and here he was alone with only Grape-Nuts
Tight against his chest. And what he wanted
Was his mother's old Simon and Garfunkel albums,
Something soft, like Lacey.

Suddenly, he knew he had to
get her attention . . . had to make her see him
had to had to had to . . . that's when

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all reason, all intelligence, all hope of
ever being considered normal again
left his body, walked right out through his skin
stranded him in cereal, where he set the Grape-Nuts
down in the middle of Fruity Pebbles and

without a thought grabbed an empty shopping cart,
a wide-nosed bundle of stainless steel,
and began to run.

Up and down the rows he went.
Past the bins of onions and Irish potatoes,
The yellow squash and broccoli heads,
Past Orville Redenbacher and Sun-Maid Raisins,
Down the rows of canned vegetables,
Earlyspringpeas-artichokehearts-limabeans-navybeans
Greatnorthernbeans-creamedstylecorn-hominy
The colors flew by in a rainbow beside his vision
Faster he went, then faster and faster,
The basket hummed in front of him. He saw the rice
and pasta, the rows of spaghetti sauce –

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Mama mia, holy Toledo, shazam!
He's almost there, only frozen foods between
Them, Stouffer's, Borden, Pepperidge Farm,
Faster, faster, he pushes, he pushes, then all at once
The cart is pulling, pulling, pulling . . .
He's hanging on with all his might.

The cart has taken over. It pulls him past meat
And cheese, past paper goods, past pet food,
Past the young night manager Roy.

Finally, the magazines! And just past that –
The paperbacks – romances, adventures, comics,
How-tos, bestsellers, Lacey!

His stomach cramps, his legs drag.
He can do this. He knows he can. He must do this.
Then, just as he nears the turn, he leaps . . .

The air rushes beneath him, his body flies above
The green and white linoleum, he pulls himself forward

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Both feet are on the bottom bar now,
His palms sweat, he's breathing hard, he takes a gulp,
With a mighty heave he jerks the cart toward him

Did he do it? Could he do it? Is he flying?
Yes!

Victory! He and the cart are one
Balanced on its tow back wheels, a wheelie to end
All wheelies! There's never been another like it
In the history of Food City. "Yeehaw," he wants to scream.
"Yeehaw!" he screams. He sails past her
And let's go with one hand, which he raises to her,
Let's go of his heart, which he throws her way,
Let's go of his senses, which he left back there in the cereal . . .
Kaboom, splat, errrrrrrt . . . he crashes into Dr. Pepper.

Is there a doctor in the house?

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What in the world possessed him?
Keebler Elves? The Jolly Green Giant?
Oscar Mayer, the great weiner himself?

He's pretty sure he'll never again hear Roy
Say, "Good job, buddy." He's certain
He's bruised his ribs. He knows for sure
That he's going to pay for all that Dr. Pepper.

But like a voice from heaven . . .
"Are you okay?"
He doesn't think he is . . .
He's sure he's not . . .
Maybe he'll walk again . . .
Oh, what difference does it make?
Al he can see is her blue apron,
Her plastic Lacey nametag,
She fills the aisle with the scent of maple
Looking down at him, so soft, and . . .

There he lay, faceup in a pool of carbonated soda,

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Soaking into his red and black shirt, bubbling into his hair, spewing
Into the florescent air, the boy who took her
Away from Dean Koontz, drew her away from all that intrigue,
Won her full attention.

Oh tell me, ye of little faith –
Who is the master of mystery now?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kathy Appelt
Book: Poems from Homeroom: A Writer's Place to Start
ISBN: 978-0805069785
Publisher: Henry Holt and Co
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2002

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier

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